

Texas Mineral Rights Data Strategy

Three-Tier Plan: Free RRC, County Scraping, Commercial Licensing

Prepared for: Location Intelligence project (statewide Texas focus)
Date: July 6, 2026
Scope: How to obtain wells, leases, operators, and courthouse mineral ownership data

Executive Summary

Your three-tier model is correct. Texas has no statewide courthouse API for mineral ownership. The practical path is: (1) pull free RRC bulk data immediately for wells/leases/operators; (2) build county-specific scrapers for deed and grantor-grantee indexes in a handful of well-digitized counties; (3) parallel-track commercial licensing conversations to avoid years of scraper maintenance. Important nuance: RRC data shows regulatory activity, not mineral title. Courthouse deeds show ownership transfers. Neither alone equals full chain of title.

Tier	Effort	Cost	What you get	Ownership?
1 - Free RRC	Low	Free	Wells, APIs, leases, operators, permits	No - activity only
2 - Scraping	High	Free (+ dev time)	Deed index, grantor/grantee, doc metadata	Partial - index, not parsed title
3 - Buy	Low ops	Paid	Statewide indexes, images, title tools	Yes - with commercial tools

Tier 1 - Free: Texas Railroad Commission (RRC)

Build immediately. No contracts. RRC is the state oil and gas regulator. Bulk ASCII, DBF, and shapefile datasets update on published schedules (daily to weekly depending on product).

How to attain RRC data

1. Start at the RRC Data Sets page (master index of all bulk downloads).
2. Follow the MFT (GoDrive) HTTPS link for each dataset - no login required for free sets.
3. Download to data/raw/rrc_cache/ and parse with Python (dbfread for DBF, pandas for ASCII).
4. Join to counties using API number (first digits encode county) or spatial join on well shapefiles.

Master index:

<https://www.rrc.texas.gov/resource-center/research/data-sets-available-for-download/>

Statewide API Data (per-county DBF, twice weekly):

<https://mft.rrc.texas.gov/link/1eb94d66-461d-4114-93f7-b4bc04a70674>

Files: api113.dbf (Dallas), api439.dbf (Tarrant), etc.

Other high-value free sets on same page:

- Full Wellbore (ASCII, weekly)
- Drilling Permit Master (ASCII, monthly)
- Well Layers by County (shapefile, twice weekly)
- Oil and Gas Field Rules (ASCII, monthly)
- Completion Information (ASCII, nightly)

Priority RRC datasets for location intelligence

Dataset	Update	Key fields	Use case
Statewide API Data	2x/week	API #, lease, survey, plug date	Well count by county
Full Wellbore	Weekly	API, depth, status, county	Active vs plugged inventory
Drilling Permits	Monthly	Permit #, API, lat/lon, field	New activity / growth
Well Layers shapefile	2x/week	Geometry, API, lease name	Map wells to parcels
Production Data Query	Monthly	Lease, operator, volumes	Producing vs non-producing

RRC download caveat (known issue)

The MFT GoDrive portal uses PrimeFaces web forms. Programmatic single-file download may require a browser session or manual download. Workarounds: (a) manual download of target county DBF files; (b) use Full Wellbore statewide ASCII instead of per-county DBF; (c) use Well Layers shapefile zip and filter by county FIPS in geopandas.

Sample pipeline command (after fetch_rrc.py is extended)

```
python -m src.fetch_rrc_wells          # per-county API DBF
python -m src.fetch_rrc_wellbore       # statewide ASCII (recommended)
python -m src.fetch_rrc_permits        # drilling permits with lat/lon
```

Tier 2 - Scraping: Target County Clerk Portals

Pick 3-5 counties with the deepest digitization and highest mineral activity. Records are public under Texas Public Information Act, but each county uses different software. Expect per-county scraper maintenance, login requirements, rate limits, and terms-of-use review before automating.

Recommended pilot counties

County	Portal	Vendor	Online depth	Mineral relevance
Harris	cclerk.hctx.net/WebSearch	Custom (Harris)	Images from 1960	Urban + legacy O&G
Midland	midland.tx.publicsearch.us	GovOS/Kofile	Full land records	Permian core
Tarrant	tarrant.tx.publicsearch.us	GovOS/Kofile	Real property + OCR	DFW + Barnett
Ector (add)	ectorcountytexas-web.tylerhost.net	Tyler EagleWeb	Odessa / Permian	High well density
Reeves (add)	reeves.tx.publicsearch.us	GovOS/Kofile	All land online + FTP bulk	Delaware Basin

What to scrape (index metadata - not full OCR initially)

Per recorded instrument:

- county_fips, instrument_number, recorded_date
- grantor, grantee, document_type
- book/volume/page (if available)
- legal_description (freeform text)
- image_url or doc_id (for later OCR pass)

Filter document types for mineral work:

- mineral deed, royalty deed, O&G lease, assignment, ratification, release, pooling, probate, affidavit of heirship

How to attain courthouse index data (per county)

Harris County:

1. Register free account at cclerk.hctx.net/Applications/WebSearch
2. Search Real Property by grantor/grantee or legal description
3. Index search is free; images \$0.10/page for non-watermarked copies
4. Scraper target: authenticated session + RP search form POST

Midland / Tarrant (GovOS PublicSearch):

1. Open county portal (no account usually required for index)
2. Use Quick Search or Advanced Search (grantor, grantee, doc type, date range)
3. Scraper target: search API calls behind publicsearch.us UI (JSON responses)
4. Enable 'Search Index & Full Text (OCR)' for keyword hits on 'minerals'

Reeves County (bulk alternative):

1. Same publicsearch.us portal for index
2. Clerk also sells FTP image bundles: \$50/week or \$200/month
3. Contact: Reeves County Clerk, Pecos TX - see reevescounty.org/departments/county-clerk

Scraper build checklist

- Map one county end-to-end before generalizing (Midland is a good first target).
- Store raw JSON/HTML in `data/raw/courthouse/{county_fips}/` with scrape timestamp.
- Normalize to a single schema: `courthouse_records.csv`.
- Respect robots.txt and rate limits (1-2 req/sec); run overnight batch jobs.
- Budget 2-4 hours/month per county for portal upgrades and CAPTCHA changes.
- Legal: public records are accessible, but automated bulk scraping may violate portal ToS - get a one-page opinion from counsel if scaling beyond research volumes.

Tier 3 - Buy vs Build: Commercial Licensing

If budget allows, one email to each vendor can clarify enterprise, nonprofit, or research pricing. Commercial access often costs less than 6-12 months of scraper engineering and maintenance for statewide coverage.

Vendor comparison

Vendor	Coverage	Contact	Typical model	Best for
CourthouseDirect	254 TX counties	information@courthousedirect.com	Geo-Index \$300/county/mo	Grantor-grantee + O&G lease check
CourthouseDirect	(800) 925-4225	API Integration page	TVP plans, \$1.50/doc	Title shops, land departments
Enverus Courthouse	~150 TX counties	enverus.com/products/courthouse	Enterprise quote	Mineral title back to sovereignty
TexasFile	254 clerk + 200+ mineral	support@texasfile.com	Bulk rolls \$500/county	Producing mineral tax rolls
TexasFile	(214) 705-6400	minerals@texasfile.com	Regional \$2.5k-\$20k/yr	Excel ownership rolls (CAD-sourced)

CourthouseDirect - how to attain access

1. Review Texas Volume Pricing: courthousedirect.com/TexasVolumePricing.aspx
2. Review API Integration page: courthousedirect.com/ProductInfo/APIIntegrationInfo.aspx
3. Email information@courthousedirect.com with:
 - Use case: mineral ownership tracking / location intelligence
 - Counties of interest: statewide or Permian + Harris + Tarrant
 - Ask: API access, bulk index licensing, nonprofit/research pricing
4. Published Geo-Index sample pricing (negotiable): \$1,200/mo all counties (index only), or \$300/county/month; \$50/seat; \$1.50/document image.

Enverus Courthouse - how to attain access

1. Visit enverus.com/products/courthouse/
2. Request demo / pricing for Texas mineral title research
3. Ask specifically about: programmatic export, county coverage list, sovereignty-depth counties, and API vs batch file delivery
4. Enverus claims 150 TX counties for document search and 29+ counties indexed back to sovereignty.

TexasFile (alternative) - mineral rolls not deed chains

TexasFile is worth a parallel quote if producing-interest ownership (tax roll) is sufficient:

- Per search: \$0.25 at texasfile.com/minerals/
- Bulk county roll: ~\$500 (Excel with owner, interest %, operator, lease, legal desc)
- Multi-county packages: \$2,500-\$20,000/year - email minerals@texasfile.com for sample roll

This is faster than deed scraping but does not replace chain-of-title from courthouse instruments.

Sample outreach email (copy/paste)

Subject: API / bulk licensing inquiry - Texas mineral & courthouse records

We are building a location intelligence platform that tracks oil & gas activity and mineral interest ownership across Texas. We are evaluating commercial data licensing vs building county scrapers.

Please share:

- 1) API or bulk file options for grantor-grantee indexes and O&G instruments
- 2) County coverage list and update frequency
- 3) Pricing for research / nonprofit / startup use (10 users, statewide)
- 4) Sample data dictionary or trial access

Target counties: Harris, Midland, Tarrant, Ector, Reeves (+ statewide if available)

Recommended Sequence

Week 1-2 (Free tier - do now):

- Download RRC Full Wellbore + Drilling Permits statewide ASCII
- Parse API numbers to county; load into SQLite alongside existing pipeline
- Manually download 5 pilot county api####.dbf files from MFT if automation blocked

Week 3-6 (Scraping tier - prove one county):

- Build Midland County scraper (GovOS template, cleanest URL pattern)
- Extract grantor/grantee index for document types: mineral deed, O&G lease, assignment
- Validate 100 known instruments against manual portal search

Week 2-4 parallel (Buy tier - one email each):

- CourthouseDirect: API / Geo-Index pricing
- Enverus: Courthouse enterprise demo
- TexasFile: sample mineral roll for Midland or Ward County

Decision gate (Week 6):

- If commercial index < 6 months engineering cost -> buy
- If not -> extend scrapers to Harris (custom) and Tarrant (GovOS), accept maintenance

What each tier does NOT give you

Gap	Why it matters	Mitigation
RRC != ownership	Shows wells/operators, not who owns minerals	Add courthouse deed tier
Index != chain of title	Grantor-grantee list is not parsed ownership %	Build graph or buy title tool
Scrape != 254 counties	Each portal is different	Commercial aggregator or phased rollout
Tax roll != all minerals	Non-producing severed minerals may be absent	Deed research for dormant rights

Key URLs (quick reference)

RRC data sets: <https://www.rrc.texas.gov/resource-center/research/data-sets-available-for-download/>

RRC MFT API DBF: <https://mft.rrc.texas.gov/link/1eb94d66-461d-4114-93f7-b4bc04a70674>

Harris clerk: <https://cclerk.hctx.net/Applications/WebSearch/Home.aspx>

Midland clerk: <https://midland.tx.publicsearch.us/>

Tarrant clerk: <https://tarrant.tx.publicsearch.us/>

Ector clerk: <https://ectorcountytexas-web.tylerhost.net/web/user/disclaimer>

Reeves clerk: <https://reeves.tx.publicsearch.us/>

CourthouseDirect: <https://www.courthousedirect.com/TexasVolumePricing.aspx>

Enverus Courthouse: <https://www.enverus.com/products/courthouse/>

TexasFile minerals: <https://www.texasfile.com/minerals/>